

who live nearby whenever a Meetup group is started, and also notifying members of groups about upcoming events. There is a *Organiser of the Week* award for meetups that gets the best feedback. Organisers have a wide support network of other experienced organisers to fall back upon. Each Meetup group has its own About page, which enumerates its aims and activities. About page design can be customised. Every week there is also a prize for the best designed About page. Memberships in groups are free or can be an amount that covers the costs of organizing the meetings, while some groups may have paid activities.

Meetup earns its revenue mainly through monthly subscriptions from Organisers, advertising and fees from organizations who use Meetup to grow their own networks. This charging from members for co-ordinating Meetups earned considerable criticism when it



A community on Ning

was introduced in April 2005 and also saw a drop in members and groups, but those that remained later on enabled Meetup to maintain a stable base and expand. Monthly subscription rates are in the region of \$12 to \$19 (depending on the plan) with a 30 day money back guarantee. An Organiser can simultaneously run 3 groups without paying additional fees, or can step down at any time. Meetup lists 29,690 groups and 3,517 topics with 60,792 meetups in June. People can also invite their friends to join Meetup.

The site had clean design and though some places looked cluttered, overall experience was good. Payments are made through PayPal and so they are secure. Registration took a few minutes and joining a group was only a click away, though Organisers have to spend time on creating a Meetup group.